

Lesson 19

Handling Workplace Issues



Warm-Up

Share your valuable experience in effectively addressing workplace issues. Your insights can inspire others to find innovative solutions and foster a collaborative environment.





Role-Play

Scenario: *Two coworkers, Tony and Jay, are having a conflict about a project deadline. The manager, Henry, intervenes to resolve the conflict.*

Scene 1: Conflict

Tony: Jay, I don't think I can meet this deadline. I have too much on my plate.

Jay: **I understand your concern**, but we need to meet this deadline. The client is expecting it.

Scene 2: Intervention

Henry: Hey, what's going on here? I can see that you're both stressed.

Tony: Jay is pushing for a deadline that's unrealistic.

Jay: Tony is not taking this project seriously.

Scene 3: Resolution

Henry: Okay, **let's find a solution**. Tony, what do you need to meet this deadline?

Tony: I need an extra day or two to ensure the quality of work.

Jay: That's doable. I can talk to the client and see if we can push the deadline back.

Henry: Great. **Let's work together to resolve this**.

Role-Play Analysis

Answer the following questions:

1. What did Henry do well in handling the conflict?
2. What could Jay have done differently?
3. How did Tony and Jay contribute to the resolution of the conflict?
4. What can we learn from this scenario about handling workplace conflict?



Useful Phrases in Handling Workplace Issues

1. **Let's work together to resolve this.** – used in conflict resolution, problem-solving, improving communication, or building trust to foster a culture of collaboration, creativity, and mutual support.

Example:

- I understand we're facing a challenge. ***Let's work together to resolve this*** and find a solution that benefits everyone.

2. **I understand your concern.** – used to acknowledge and validate emotions, diffuse tension, create a safe space for discussion, and show willingness to listen.

Example:

- ***I understand your concern about the new policy,*** and I appreciate sharing your thoughts with me.

3. **Let's find a solution.** – used in problem-solving, conflict resolution, improving processes, and/or enhancing employee engagement.

Example:

- ***Let's find a solution*** that works for everyone. Any idea?

4. **I see your point, but...** – used to acknowledge the other person's perspective while also introducing an alternative viewpoint or concern.

Example:

- ***I see your point about the new policy, but*** it's essential for maintaining compliance with the industry regulations.

5. **How can we resolve this?** – used in conflict resolution, problem-solving, improving processes, and/or addressing customer complaints.

Example:

- We are experiencing a problem with our supply chain. ***How can we resolve this*** and minimize the impact on our customers?



Practice 1

Choose the best response from a to e for each case below.

1. **Employee Conflict:** Two employees are having disagreement about a project.
Professional Response: _____
2. **Customer Complaint:** A customer is complaining about a product defect.
Professional Response: _____
3. **Employee Absenteeism:** An employee has been absent from work for several days without notification.
Professional Response: _____
4. **Performance Issues:** An employee is not meeting performance expectations.
Professional Response: _____
5. **Safety Concerns:** An employee reports a safety concern in the workplace.
Professional Response: _____

Professional responses in handling workplace issues:

- a. Alden, I've noticed that you've been absent from work for several days. Can you please provide me with a reason for your absence and let me know when you expect to return to work?
- b. While you have strengths in certain areas, there are some concerns that need to be addressed. Let's work together to create a performance improvement plan that will help you meet the expectation of your role.
- c. I apologize for the inconvenience you've experienced with our product. Can you please provide me with more information about the issue so I can assist you better.
- d. We take the safety and well-being of our employees seriously. Can you please provide me with more information about the issue so we can investigate and take corrective action.
- e. Kath and Daniel, I understand that you have differing opinions on the project. Let's schedule a meeting to discuss the issue and find a resolution that works for both of you.



Practice 2

ROLE PLAY EXERCISE

Instructions:

Objective: To practice effective communication, active listening, and conflict resolution skills in handling workplace issues.

Scenario: An employee (you) is experiencing a conflict with his team leader (partner) regarding workload and responsibilities. You feel overwhelmed and undervalued, while your team leader believes you're not taking enough initiative.

1. Choose a partner to role play the scenario.
2. Set a timer for 5-10 minutes.
3. Start the role-play and begin by expressing concerns and frustrations or listening to concerns or feedback.
4. Respond to each other, and work together to find a solution.
5. If time permits, switch roles.



Production

Be more confident in handling workplace issues by answering the following questions.

1. How can we address the employees' concerns in a fair and timely manner?
2. In communication issues, how can we ensure that all parties are on the same page?
3. What are the specific performance issues that need to be addressed?
4. How can we maintain a positive and productive working relationship?
5. How can we prevent similar conflicts from arising in the future?



Key Vocabulary

Word/Phrase	Use	Example
Dispute resolution	Used in resolving conflicts between two or more parties through mediation, arbitration, negotiation, or litigation.	The company's dispute resolution process helped the contract issue with the supplier, avoiding costly litigation.
Clarify misunderstandings	Used to prevent miscommunication, build trust, save time, and improve relationships.	To ensure we're on the same page, let me clarify your expectations for the project.
Escalate an issue	Used in bringing a problem or concern to the attention of a higher authority to seek resolution or guidance.	We are escalating this technical issue to our senior engineers, as it requires specialized expertise.
Resolve a conflict	Used to maintain healthy relationships, productivity and reputation.	The management team were able to resolve the conflict with the union and reach a mutually beneficial agreement.
Mediate between parties	Used in facilitating a negotiation between two or more parties in conflict to help them reach a mutually acceptable agreement.	The supervisor mediated a discussion between the employee and customer to resolve the complaint.
Find a compromise	Used in reaching a mutually acceptable agreement between two or more parties with different interests, needs, or goals.	We were able to find a compromise on the project deadline, giving us more time to complete it.



Wrap-Up

Conflict can be sensitive, often involving strong emotions. Allowing those involved to take ownership and collaborate on a solution can lead to lasting results. Ask open-ended questions about what happened, avoiding accusations or commands, and encourage them to suggest a course of action.